Ben Hays

Creative Developer | Interactive Systems & Front-End Architecture

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Award-winning Creative Developer (Awwwards Honorable Mention & GSAP Site of the Day) with 20+ years of engineering experience at the intersection of design and code. My career spans two halves: 10 years building scalable front-end systems at Kajabi and 10 years creating high-fidelity interactive work for brands like Disney, Pixar, and AWS. Expert in **TypeScript** and modern frameworks (**React, Svelte, Angular, Vue**), I specialize in bridging complex system logic with premium, brand-aware visual execution.

SKILLS

- **Creative Technology**: GSAP, WebGL, Three.js, React Three Fiber, PixiJS, GLSL Shaders, Framer Motion.
- **Interaction & Motion**: Polished, tactile, and brand-aware interfaces using easing, stagger, and motion systems that feel responsive and intentional.
- **Architecture & Logic**: TypeScript, React, Svelte, Angular, Vue, Node.js, Tailwind CSS, WebSockets, Design Systems Architecture, State Management: Redux, Zustand, MobX.
- **AI Workflow**: Daily use of Claude, Cursor, Gemini, ChatGPT, and Copilot to prototype, scaffold, and refine ideas quickly without sacrificing code quality.

PROJECTS

- **Benzo the Great** (benhays.dev) **(Award-Winning Portfolio)**: Recipient of **GSAP Site of the Day** and **Awwwards Honorable Mention**. A masterclass in high-fidelity motion, performance-driven WebGL, and interactive storytelling.
- **Lorcana 3D Carousel** (lorcana.benhays.dev): A **React Three Fiber** experiment exploring dynamic lighting, tilt, and performance-focused 3D motion.
- **Legal Graffiti** (tagtoy.benhays.dev): A real-time **WebGPU** graffiti simulator for user-driven visual expression with zero-latency rendering.
- **Rivian Navbar** (rivian.benhays.dev): High-fidelity UX rebuild using **Svelte**, focusing on sleek micro-interactions and state transitions.

EXPERIENCE

Wildlife | Los Angeles, CA

Creative Developer (Contract) | Oct 2025 - Feb 2026

- **High-Precision Sync Architecture**: Engineered a custom **TypeScript** and **WebSocket** communication layer for AWS re:Invent kiosks, syncing tablet controllers with large-scale displays with zero perceptible lag.
- **Generative Ambient Environments**: Built a high-performance **WebGL** "lava lamp" mesh system using custom shaders to create fluid backgrounds that held 60fps under heavy UI load.
- **Administrative Infrastructure**: Built a custom **TypeScript** debug panel for real-time state monitoring and environment resets during live operation.
- **High-Fidelity UI**: Used **Tailwind CSS** and **GSAP** to build polished interactive layers for the AWS installation, supporting fast iteration and visual consistency.
- **Platform Adaptation**: Re-architected the live event codebase into a standalone **TypeScript** desktop experience, preserving all high-fidelity visuals and leaderboard logic for public browser access.

Kajabi | Irvine, CA

Lead Creative Engineer (Founding Front-End Engineer) | Oct 2013 - Dec 2024

- **Platform Evolution**: Joined as the company's sole front-end engineer and helped scale the platform through a decade of growth into a market leader serving 100,000+ creators.
- **Creative Engine Architecture**: Architected the Encore theme system, giving creators the flexibility to build custom, animated, high-performance web experiences at scale.
- **Interactive Tooling**: Built the in-browser visual editors and the "Benstrap" design system, helping bridge deep engineering systems with intuitive user-facing tools.
- **Performance Optimization**: Managed the balance between creative freedom and strict **Core Web Vitals**, **SEO**, and performance requirements across millions of pages.
- **Engineering Leadership**: Established the organization's front-end standards and mentored a team of developers into current Staff SRE and Senior Engineering roles.

Hooky Interactive | Santa Monica, CA

Creative Developer | Jul 2008 - Jul 2013

- **Studio Campaign Leadership**: Served as Lead Developer for high-traffic, high-visibility interactive campaigns for **Disney, Pixar, Fox, Sony Pictures, and DreamWorks**.
- **The Big Hits**: Built the **South Park Avatar Creator**, a viral character-generation engine used by millions of fans worldwide.
- **Immersive Web Experiences**: Developed the **U2 360° Tour website**, a pioneering 3D web experience that blended performance footage with real-time interactive 3D exploration.
- **Global Brand Microsites**: Engineered high-engagement digital experiences for **KIA, Lexus, and Honda**, ensuring cross-browser compatibility during the early mobile-web transition.

Studio 318 | Sorrento Valley, CA

Graphic Designer | Mar 2007 - Jun 2008

- **Design DNA**: Developed print and brand collateral for **Sea World, Irvine Company, and Jazzercise**, establishing the visual-first foundation for my transition into creative code.

EDUCATION

The Art Institute of California, San Diego

Focus: Graphic Design & Illustration